

Code of Conduct

NovaTech Innovations Inc.

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1. Introduction to Business Ethics

The Foundation of Our Reputation

The Code of Conduct is the cornerstone of NovaTech Innovations' corporate culture. It sets the standard for how we conduct ourselves daily—ethically, legally, and professionally. Our reputation as an industry leader is built on trust, and this Code ensures we maintain that trust with our clients, partners, and each other.

Every employee, regardless of their position or location, is bound by this Code. It is not merely a set of rules, but a reflection of our core values in action.

2. Respect in the Workplace

Anti-Discrimination and Equal Opportunity

NovaTech is committed to providing a work environment free from discrimination. We make all employment decisions—including hiring, promotions, training, and termination—based on merit, qualifications, and business needs.

Discrimination based on race, color, religion, gender identity, sexual orientation, national origin, age, disability, marital status, or any other legally protected characteristic is strictly prohibited.

Anti-Harassment and Bullying

We have a zero-tolerance policy towards harassment and bullying in any form. This includes verbal, physical, visual, and sexual harassment.

Unwelcome conduct, offensive jokes, slurs, physical intimidation, or the circulation of inappropriate imagery creates a hostile work environment and will result in severe disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

3. Conflict of Interest

Defining Conflicts of Interest

A conflict of interest arises when an employee's personal interests interfere, or appear to interfere, with the best interests of NovaTech Innovations. Employees must make business decisions entirely free from personal bias or financial gain.

Examples include holding a financial interest in a competitor or supplier, accepting substantial gifts from vendors, or employing family members as direct subordinates.

Disclosure Procedures

If an employee finds themselves in a situation that may constitute a potential conflict of interest, they must disclose the relationship or situation immediately to their manager and the Legal Department.

The Legal Department will assess the situation and provide written guidance on how to manage or eliminate the conflict.

4. Protection of Assets and Confidentiality

Safeguarding Company Assets

Employees are entrusted with company assets, including laptops, mobile devices, software, office supplies, and financial resources. These assets must be used efficiently, ethically, and strictly for legitimate business purposes.

Theft, carelessness, and waste have a direct impact on the company's profitability. Any suspected fraud or theft should be reported immediately.

Confidentiality and Intellectual Property

Information is one of our most valuable assets. Employees have access to proprietary trade secrets, client lists, financial data, and unreleased product roadmaps.

Employees are bound by non-disclosure agreements to keep this information strictly confidential, both during and after their employment with NovaTech. Sharing confidential information on personal social media or with unauthorized third parties is a severe legal violation.

5. Communication and Public Relations

Social Media Guidelines

While NovaTech respects employees' rights to personal social media usage, employees must be mindful that they represent the company. Do not post discriminatory, defamatory, or harassing content.

Employees must clearly state that their views are their own and do not represent the company when discussing industry topics. Never share confidential company information online.

Media Inquiries

Only designated spokespersons from the Public Relations department are authorized to speak on behalf of NovaTech Innovations to the media, analysts, or investors. If approached by a journalist, employees must politely decline and direct the inquiry to the PR team.

6. Roles and Responsibilities

Employee Responsibilities

Every employee at NovaTech Innovations is expected to familiarize themselves thoroughly with the Code of Conduct. Ignorance of the policy is not an acceptable excuse for non-compliance. Employees must actively apply these guidelines in their daily routines and decision-making processes.

It is the duty of the employee to seek clarification from their direct manager or the Human Resources department if any aspect of this policy is unclear. Furthermore, employees are required to report any known or suspected violations of this policy immediately through the appropriate channels.

- Read and acknowledge receipt of the policy document annually.
- Participate in mandatory compliance training sessions.
- Maintain transparency and open communication with management.
- Cooperate fully during any internal investigations related to policy breaches.

Managerial Responsibilities

Managers and supervisors act as the primary enforcers and role models for the Code of Conduct. They must ensure that their team members understand and adhere to all stipulations contained herein.

Managers are also responsible for consistently applying this policy without bias or favoritism. Any discrepancies in enforcement can lead to legal liabilities and a breakdown in team morale.

- Provide guidance and support to team members regarding policy details.

- Monitor compliance within their respective departments.
- Document and address any minor infractions through coaching and verbal warnings.
- Escalate severe or repeated violations to Human Resources.

Human Resources Responsibilities

The Human Resources (HR) department is the ultimate owner of the Code of Conduct. HR is tasked with ensuring the policy remains compliant with local, state, and federal laws, updating it as necessary to reflect organizational changes or legal requirements.

HR serves as an impartial mediator and investigator in cases where policy violations are reported. They are responsible for administering disciplinary actions in a fair and documented manner.

7. Policy Enforcement and Disciplinary Action

Progressive Discipline Framework

NovaTech Innovations employs a progressive discipline model to address violations of company policies. The goal of this framework is to correct undesired behavior and provide employees with the opportunity to improve, rather than immediately resorting to punitive measures.

However, the company reserves the right to bypass progressive steps and proceed directly to severe disciplinary action, including termination, for egregious offenses.

- Step 1: Verbal Warning - A documented conversation outlining the infraction and expected corrections.
- Step 2: Written Warning - A formal document placed in the employee's personnel file, detailing the failure to improve.
- Step 3: Final Written Warning / Suspension - Severe warning that may include unpaid suspension pending investigation.
- Step 4: Termination of Employment - Final action taken when previous steps fail or the offense is critically severe.

Investigation Procedures

Upon receiving a report of a policy violation, HR will initiate a prompt, thorough, and objective investigation. All parties involved, including witnesses, will be interviewed, and relevant documentation will be reviewed.

Confidentiality will be maintained to the highest degree possible throughout the investigation process to protect the privacy of the complainant, the accused, and any witnesses.

8. Review, Revisions, and Acknowledgement

Annual Review Cycle

The Code of Conduct is subject to an annual review by the executive committee and legal counsel. This ensures that the policy aligns with the evolving strategic goals of NovaTech Innovations and complies with all relevant employment laws.

Employees will be notified of any substantive changes to the policy via official company communication channels. Updated versions will be immediately available on the company intranet.

Employee Acknowledgement

Upon joining the company, and subsequently upon any major revision of this policy, employees will be required to sign a digital acknowledgement form. This form certifies that they have read, understood, and agreed to comply with the terms set forth.

Failure to sign the acknowledgement form does not exempt an employee from the requirement to adhere to the policy.